



**PRACHANDA (CENTRE)
WITH MUKHERJEE AT
KATHMANDU IN DECEMBER**

day-to-day battle for survival. Rahul Shrestha, who runs a cybercafé in Thamel, Kathmandu, fights 16 to 18 hour long power cuts on a daily basis. "I do not care who becomes the prime minister. I need to earn my livelihood and with such long power cuts, it is very difficult," he says.

In the midst of all the arithmetic, the Maoists are sitting back with the confidence that without them no government will be able to work. They demonstrated this on May 5 when they disrupted Parliament. "We will not let

the government work. Through dialogue, peaceful street protests and protests in Parliament, we will stall everything until the President takes his decision to reinstate the General back," says Deenanath Sharma, the operative word being "peaceful". A huge rally that marched through King's Way in the heart of Kathmandu on May 5 passed off peacefully. The PLA cadres, 30 per cent of whom are out of the cantonments where they have been confined under the agreement with the UN, are at the forefront of the protests. The

Maoists, with 19,000-plus cadres, are the only political party in Nepal with an armed wing. But how true these figures are remains to be seen given a January 2008 video tape that has surfaced. The video shows Prachanda boasting to his cadres about how he had hoodwinked the UN into believing that the 7,000-strong PLA actually had 35,000 members. The UN eventually verified 19,602 cadres, all of whom are now receiving Rs 5,000 per month and free rations from the World Bank.

At a press conference held on May 6, Prachanda tried to save face, saying he was referring only to the regular army not the Territorial Army and the militia. He also used the press conference to do some double-speak on India. "We want neighbourly relations with our neighbours—India and China. We want diplomatic relations with the other countries of the world. But we will not tolerate any interference in our domestic affairs. I never mentioned India by name.... I will continue to say that India's role in the peace process has been very constructive.... We are satisfied with the statement of the Indian foreign minister." However, since India bashing is the flavour of any season in Nepal, it is the unspoken pro-China feeling that should be a cause for worry for India.

What is encouraging is that the protest rallies have remained peaceful till now. "There is no reason for the Maoists to resort to violence. All the cards are stacked in their favour. Why should they ruin everything by resorting to violence?" says a senior government functionary. For India, the immediate concern is twofold: a new government in New Delhi will not want to be saddled with security concerns along its 1,690-km open border with Nepal. It would prefer an interim government to be in place and a constitution which would pave the way for a durable democratic government. Another key concern for India is that the three-year-old peace process in Kathmandu is not consigned to history. Maintaining its strategic interests in the face of a hostile environment and Beijing's shadow play will be a Himalayan challenge. ■



**AN ALL-PARTY MEETING IN KATHMANDU
TO FORGE A CONSENSUS ON
A NEW GOVERNMENT**